

Troubleshooting Guide: WhatsApp Desktop

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1.0	February 10, 2026	Gokul S Anand	Initial draft created
1.1	February 10, 2026	Gokul S Anand	Updated troubleshooting workflow, improved escalation process, and corrected technical inaccuracies
1.2	May 11, 2026	Gokul S Anand	Updated some sentences and words

 **Disclaimer:** This troubleshooting guide is created as a technical writing portfolio sample and is not affiliated with Meta Platforms, Inc.

1. Purpose

This guide provides structured troubleshooting procedures for common issues encountered in the WhatsApp Desktop app for Windows.

2. Scope

2.1 Included

This troubleshooting guide covers common issues related to the WhatsApp Desktop app. This includes troubleshooting steps for:

- Installation and update failures.
- Login and account access issues.
- Message send and receive issues.
- Chat backup issues.

2.2 Not Included

This troubleshooting guide does not cover the following:

- WhatsApp web issues.
- Mobile app troubleshooting.
- Administrative settings managed through WhatsApp on the web or the application Admin Center.
- Service outage diagnosis — confirmed outages must be escalated.

3. Intended Audience

This guide is intended for:

- End users
- IT support teams.

4. Prerequisites

Before you begin, ensure the following basic requirements are met:

- Administrator rights to install applications.
 - Windows version 10 or later.
 - Internet connection.
 - A valid phone number registered with WhatsApp.
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5. Troubleshooting Workflow

1. Identify the issue by capturing the exact error message and confirming the user environment.
2. Perform basic checks, including verifying network connectivity, restarting WhatsApp Desktop, and confirming WhatsApp service health status through the Meta Admin Center, if applicable.
3. Apply targeted troubleshooting steps based on the identified issue.
4. Validate the resolution by confirming that the issue is resolved and the user can successfully perform the expected task.
5. Escalate the issue if unresolved by collecting relevant screenshots and log files and escalating according to the escalation matrix.

6. Troubleshooting Issues and Solutions

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-001

Issue Name: WhatsApp desktop fails to launch

Symptoms:

- The application does not open after clicking the icon.
- No window appears on the screen.
- The system does not display any error messages.

Possible causes:

- Corrupted installation files
- Outdated application versions
- Conflicting background processes

Resolution steps:

1. Restart the computer and relaunch the application.
2. Check and install any available application updates.
3. If the problem continues, uninstall WhatsApp Desktop. Then, reinstall it from the official website.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop launches successfully.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-002

Issue Name: QR code not displaying for login

Symptoms:

- The QR code screen appears blank.
- A loading indicator appears that does not resolve.
- The application is stuck on the login screen.

Possible causes:

- Unstable internet connection
- WhatsApp server-side issues
- Outdated application version

Resolution steps:

1. Verify that the device has a stable internet connection.
2. Close and reopen the application to refresh the QR code screen.
3. Update WhatsApp Desktop to the latest available version.
4. Clear the application cache and attempt to log in again.

Expected result: The QR code is displayed without errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-003

Issue Name: Phone and desktop messages failing to synchronize

Symptoms:

- Messages sent or received on the mobile device do not appear on the desktop.
- There is a significant delay in message delivery.
- Chat history is incomplete on the desktop.

Possible causes:

- The mobile device is offline.
- The linked device session has expired.
- A sync interruption has occurred.

Resolution steps:

1. Ensure the mobile device is connected to the internet.
2. Open WhatsApp on the phone and allow it to sync.
3. Restart WhatsApp Desktop to start a new sync.
4. If the problem continues, open WhatsApp on your mobile, go to **Linked Devices**, and scan the QR code on the desktop login screen.

Expected result: All messages are synchronized without any error.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-004

Issue Name: WhatsApp desktop not connecting to the internet

Symptoms:

- The application continuously displays a "Connecting..." message
- A "No Internet Connection" warning is shown.
- Messages do not load or send.

Possible causes:

- Firewall or antivirus software is blocking WhatsApp.
- Incorrect proxy settings
- Unstable or unavailable network connections

Resolution steps:

1. Check if the device is connected to the internet.
2. Disable firewall or antivirus software to test the connection.
3. Check proxy settings. Make sure they aren't blocking the application.
4. Restart the router. Then, relaunch WhatsApp Desktop.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop connects to the internet successfully.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-005

Issue Name: Notifications not appearing

Symptoms:

- No notifications are received for new messages.
- No sounds play when you receive a message or a call.
- The task bar icon fails to show an unread message badge.

Possible causes:

- Notifications are disabled in the system settings.
- Do Not Disturb mode is active.
- Notification permissions have not been granted to WhatsApp.

Resolution steps:

1. Open **System notification settings** and ensure that WhatsApp is allowed to send notifications.
2. Confirm that **Do Not Disturb mode** is turned off.
3. Open **WhatsApp Desktop settings** and verify that notifications are enabled.
4. Restart the application.

Expected result: Desktop notifications appear without any error.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-006

Issue Name: Unable to send or receive media files

Symptoms:

- Images, videos, and documents fail to upload or download.
- The loading indicator keeps spinning. It doesn't finish the transfer.
- An error message appears when attempting to share media.

Possible causes:

- Insufficient storage space on the device.
- Slow or unstable internet connection.
- The file exceeds WhatsApp's size limits.

Resolution steps:

1. Free up storage space on the device.
2. Check the internet connection.

3. Verify that the file meets WhatsApp's size limits.
4. Restart the application and attempt to transfer the file again.

Expected result: Media files are sent and received successfully without any errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-007

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop Crashing Unexpectedly

Symptoms:

- The application closes on its own without any warning.
- No error message appears when it's closed.
- The crash occurs repeatedly during normal use.

Possible causes:

- Insufficient system RAM
- Software conflicts with other installed applications.
- Corrupted application data or cache.
- Outdated application versions

Resolution steps:

1. Close unnecessary background applications.
2. Update WhatsApp Desktop.
3. Clear the application cache.
4. If the problem continues, uninstall the app. Then, do a fresh reinstall.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop operates stably without crashes.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-008

Issue Name: Audio not working during voice calls

Symptoms:

- The user cannot hear the other party during a call.
- The microphone does not send audio.
- Audio cuts in and out during the conversation.

Possible causes:

- The wrong audio input or output device was chosen in system settings.
- Microphone permission is not allowed on WhatsApp.
- Outdated or faulty audio drivers.

Resolution steps:

1. Open the system **Sound settings** and ensure the correct microphone and speaker are selected.
2. Allow WhatsApp Desktop to use the microphone in the system's **Privacy settings**.
3. Update audio drivers to the latest version.

Expected result: Audio is clear during voice calls.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-009

Issue Name: Video Call Camera Not Working

Symptoms:

- The video call doesn't show the camera feed.
- The video window shows a black screen.

Possible causes:

- Camera permission is not granted.
- The camera is currently in use by another application.
- Outdated or faulty camera drivers.

Resolution steps:

1. Allow WhatsApp Desktop to use the camera in the system's **Privacy settings**.
2. Close all other applications that may be using the camera.
3. Update the camera driver to the latest version.
4. Restart the application and attempt the video call again.

Expected result: The video call works without any errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-010

Issue Name: WhatsApp desktop logged out automatically

Symptoms:

- Unexpectedly logged out of WhatsApp Desktop.
- The app asks the user to scan the QR code again.
- All chat history is gone from the desktop view.

Possible causes:

- The linked device was manually removed from the mobile device.
- The session ended because it had been inactive for too long.
- A WhatsApp update on the mobile device reset the session.

Resolution steps:

1. Open WhatsApp on the mobile device and navigate to **Linked Devices**.
2. Check whether the desktop device is still listed.
3. If removed, re-link the desktop by scanning the QR code on the login screen.
4. Ensure the mobile device remains connected to the internet to maintain the session.

Expected result: The user successfully logs back in to WhatsApp Desktop.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-011

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop displaying incorrect messages

Symptoms:

- The chat history on the desktop is old or missing some parts.
- Messages visible on the mobile device do not appear on the desktop.
- Previously deleted messages reappeared on the desktop.

Possible causes:

- Sync delay between the phone and the desktop.
- Local cache data is corrupted.
- Connection issue while syncing.

Resolution steps:

1. Ensure that both the mobile device and the desktop are connected to the internet.
2. Refresh the app by closing and reopening it.
3. Clear the WhatsApp desktop cache.
4. Unlink and relink the desktop device to force a full re-sync.

Expected result: Chat history is consistent and up to date.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-012

Issue Name: Unable to make or receive calls on desktop

Symptoms:

- The system grays out or makes the call button unresponsive.
- Calls fail to connect after dialing.
- Incoming calls do not ring or appear on the desktop.

Possible causes:

- The call feature is disabled in WhatsApp Desktop settings.
- This feature is not supported in the user's region.
- A firewall or network restriction is blocking call traffic.

Resolution steps:

1. Verify that calls are enabled in **WhatsApp Desktop settings**.
2. Ensure the network connection is stable and sufficient for voice or video calls.
3. Check that no firewall rules are blocking WhatsApp call traffic.
4. Update the application to the latest version and restart.

Expected result: Can make and receive calls without any errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-013

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop running slowly

Symptoms:

- The application responds slowly to user actions.

- Chats take a long time to load.
- The application freezes temporarily and becomes unresponsive.

Possible causes:

- High memory usage by other background applications.
- A large amount of chat history and media is stored locally.
- Outdated application version.

Resolution steps:

1. Close unnecessary background applications to free up system resources.
2. Clear the WhatsApp desktop cache.
3. Delete old chats that contain large media files.
4. Update WhatsApp Desktop to the latest available version.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop runs smoothly without any lag.

Issue ID: **TG-WHATSAPP-014**

Issue Name: Spell check or auto correct not working

Symptoms:

- Spelling errors are not underlined or highlighted while typing.
- Auto correct does not suggest corrections.
- The feature was previously working, but has stopped.

Possible causes:

- Spell check is disabled in the application settings.
- Incorrect language is selected in the application.

Resolution steps:

1. Open **WhatsApp Desktop settings** and confirm that **Spell check** is enabled.
2. Verify that the correct language is selected within the application.
3. Restart the application.
4. If the issue continues, update the app to the latest version.

Expected result: Spell check or auto correct is working successfully without any errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-015

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop not updating

Symptoms:

- The app remains on an older version after trying to update.
- The update option is unavailable.
- An error message appears during the update process.

Possible causes:

- No internet access during the update process.
- The update was blocked by system permissions or antivirus software.
- The application was not installed from an official source.

Resolution steps:

1. Ensure the device has a stable internet connection before updating.
2. Run WhatsApp Desktop with administrator privileges and attempt the update again.
3. Temporarily disable antivirus software during the update process.
4. If the issue continues, manually download the latest installer from the official WhatsApp website and install it.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop is updated successfully.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-016

Issue Name: Contact names not displaying correctly

Symptoms:

- Contacts appear as phone numbers instead of saved names.
- Contact names are missing or blank in the chat list.
- Some contacts display correctly while others do not.

Possible causes:

- Mobile device lost sync with the desktop.

- Contacts were not imported correctly during the initial link.
- A temporary sync error has occurred.

Resolution steps:

1. Ensure that the mobile device is connected to the internet and WhatsApp is open in the background.
2. Restart WhatsApp Desktop to re-sync contacts.
3. If the issue continues, unlink and re-link the desktop device.
4. Verify that contacts are saved correctly on the mobile device.

Expected result: All contact names are displayed correctly throughout the WhatsApp Desktop.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-017

Issue Name: Emojis or special characters not displaying

Symptoms:

- Emojis appear as blank squares or question marks.
- The issue occurs when receiving messages from other users.

Possible causes:

- The operating system does not support the emoji set being used.
- The application is running on an outdated version.
- Required font files are missing from the system.

Resolution steps:

1. Update WhatsApp Desktop to the latest version.
2. Update your operating system to ensure current emoji font support.
3. Restart the application after all updates have been applied.
4. If the issue continues, reinstall the application to restore any missing files.

Expected result: Emojis and special characters are displayed correctly without any errors.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-018

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop showing incorrect unread message count

Symptoms:

- The app shows an unread count that does not match the actual unread messages.
- The count does not decrease after reading messages.
- The count is displayed even when there are no unread messages.

Possible causes:

- A sync error between the mobile device and the desktop
- Display bug caused by cached notification data
- Notifications from archived or muted chats are being counted incorrectly.

Resolution steps:

1. Open and read all chats to clear the unread count.
2. Restart WhatsApp Desktop.
3. Clear the application cache and relaunch.
4. If the issue continues, unlink and re-link the desktop device.

Expected result: The unread message count is accurate and correct.

Issue ID: TG-WHATSAPP-019

Issue Name: Unable to access WhatsApp Desktop settings

Symptoms:

- The settings menu does not open when selected.
- Settings options are greyed out and cannot be interacted with.
- Changes made in the settings are not saved after the application is restarted.

Possible causes:

- An application bug or glitch
- Corrupted user profile or application data
- Insufficient system permissions granted to the application

Resolution steps:

1. Restart WhatsApp Desktop and try to access the **Settings menu** again.

2. Clear the application cache and relaunch.
3. Ensure the application is running with the required system permissions.
4. If the issue continues, uninstall and reinstall the app.

Expected result: The settings menu opens correctly without any error.

Issue ID: `TG-WHATSAPP-020`

Issue Name: WhatsApp Desktop installation failing

Symptoms:

- The installation process stops without completing.
- An error code is displayed during installation.
- The application does not appear on the system after installation finishes.

Possible causes:

- Insufficient disk space on the device
- The installer is not being run with administrator privileges.
- The installer file is corrupted or incomplete.

Resolution steps:

1. Ensure that sufficient disk space is available before beginning installation.
2. Right-click the installer and select **Run as Administrator**.
3. Download a fresh copy of the installer from the official WhatsApp website.
4. Temporarily disable antivirus software during installation.

Expected result: WhatsApp Desktop installs successfully.

 **Note:** If an issue is not resolved after completing the steps above, do the following:

- Collect screenshots.
 - Gather system information.
 - Escalate according to the Escalation Matrix (Section 7).
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7. Escalation Matrix

LEVEL	TEAM	WHEN TO ESCALATE	ACTION TAKEN
L1	IT Help desk	Issue unresolved after basic troubleshooting	Perform initial diagnostics
L2	Application Support	Issue impacts multiple users or departments	Analyze logs and configurations
L3	Vendor Support (Meta)	Technical issues or confirmed service outage	Logs, error codes, and reproduction steps documented and escalated to vendor support

8. Known Limitations and Issues

- WhatsApp Desktop requires an active internet connection on the linked phone for initial device linking and occasional re-verification.
- The desktop app may consume high RAM usage, especially after the transition to the WebView2-based version.
- Some mobile features, such as Status editing and certain privacy settings, are limited or unavailable on the Windows desktop version.
- Notifications may fail to appear if Windows notification permissions are disabled or misconfigured.
- The app may force mandatory updates, preventing older versions from functioning properly.

9. FAQ

This section answers common questions related to WhatsApp Desktop installation and usage issues.

Q1. Why does the WhatsApp Desktop installation fail?

A: Check that your system meets the basic software and hardware needs to install WhatsApp Desktop. Ensure you download the latest **installer** from the official website.

Q2. Why am I not receiving the verification code for my WhatsApp account?

A: Ensure the correct phone is entered. Check **account recovery settings**. If **multi-factor authentication** is enabled, verify the selected authentication method.

Q3. The WhatsApp Desktop is not opening. Why not?

A: Ensure the system meets the minimum software and hardware requirements. If the issue persists, try launching WhatsApp in Safe Mode or reinstalling WhatsApp Desktop from the official website.

Q4. Where are WhatsApp Desktop log files stored?

A: C:\Users\<Username>\AppData\Roaming\WhatsApp Desktop\logs

10. References

- WhatsApp Help Centre: <https://faq.whatsapp.com/>
- Official WhatsApp Desktop download link: <https://www.whatsapp.com/download>

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